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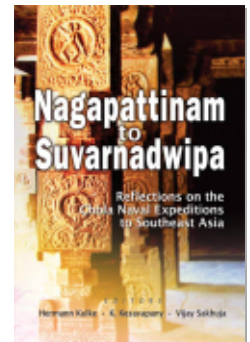
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RETHINKING COMMUNITY The Indic Carvings of Quanzhou

Risha Lee

INTRODUCTION

In the late thirteenth century, a Tamil-speaking community in southern China's coastal city of Quanzhou built a temple devoted to the Hindu god Siva. The temple is no longer intact, but over 300 carvings are still within the city, on display in the collection of the local museum, and rebuilt into the walls of the city's main Buddhist temple.¹ The known carvings are distinguishable by their South Indian style, with its closest parallels in thirteenth century temples constructed in the Kaveri Delta Region in Tamil Nadu, and are dispersed across five primary sites in Quanzhou and its surroundings. Almost all are carved with greenish-gray granite, which was widely available in the nearby hills and used frequently in the region's contemporaneous architecture.² The remains attest to the presence of a settled South Indian community in southern China during the late thirteenth century and indicate an even longer history of cross-cultural exchange between China and India.

Scholars have charted the movement and motivations of the twelfth to thirteenth century Sino-Indian exchange, analyzing the Indic carvings to show persistent cultural and mercantile relations between the two regions. However, existing scholarship stops short of reading from the carvings a fresh politics of culture and identity, one that challenges today's regnant theories in philosophy, history, and political theory. For, as I will show, the carvings resist a binary understanding of cultural interaction, where bounded,

definable cultures or ethnicities “influenced” one another. Indeed, I argue that neither the temple patrons in Quanzhou, nor the city’s local artisans, viewed themselves as culturally distinct selves or others when they interacted. Quanzhou’s Indic carvings, I argue, index an active translation of ideas and images in built-form.³

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

What little we know of the community of Siva worshippers in Quanzhou comes directly from the carvings themselves; apart from the material remains of a Siva temple, history has not documented or referenced its creators. The strongest evidence for its construction date is a bilingual inscription found in Quanzhou, written in both Chinese and Tamil on a block of diabase stone, which records the consecration of a Siva temple in 1281.⁴ This date is appropriate, given the striking stylistic correspondence of Quanzhou’s Indic carvings with contemporaneous temples in Tamil Nadu, India. Although it is impossible to know for certain where the temple was originally located since it is now dismantled, many sources suggest the southern part of the city.⁵ Most of the carvings were found within the Tonghuai gate, located in the southeastern part of the city, when the city wall was demolished in 1947.⁶ This gate was erected during the Ming dynasty (1368–1644), and the carvings were used as building materials to expand the city wall. Although we do not know the exact dates for the dismantling of the temple, this suggests that it could have occurred between the late fourteenth and seventeenth centuries.⁷ Additionally, there are scattered historical references to Indians living in the southern part of Quanzhou. Zhao Rugua records in his ca. 1225 *Description of Barbarian Peoples* that foreign merchants living in Quanzhou revered an Indian monk who arrived by sea in 985 and bought a plot of land in the southern part of Quanzhou, aiming to build a temple. Furthermore, a gazetteer from Jingzhang county — perhaps referencing a Hindu temple tank⁸ — notes that in ancient times a pool of the “foreign temple of Buddhism” existed in the city’s south. Several sources suggest that the southern suburb was the city’s commercial centre throughout the Song (960–1279) and Yuan (1279–1368) dynasties, which has led scholars to believe that the temple was once located in the city’s southern sector since the community of Siva worshippers most likely comprised merchants.⁹

In Chinese history, the 1281 inscription date places the temple in the Yuan dynasty period, initiated by Genghis Khan, a member of a nomadic tribe of ethnic Mongols. After uniting Mongolia in 1206, Genghis Khan extended his empire, which came to include large parts of Asia, the Middle

East, and some parts of Europe. While Genghis Khan did not live to see a complete conquest of China, after his death in 1259 Kublai Khan (r.1260–1294) continued his grandfather's war against the Song empire until 1279, when he took the last Song outpost in Guangzhou in southern China. Ultimately, it was the foreign community in Quanzhou, composed of South Indians, Arabs, Persians, and others, that played a pivotal role in the Mongols' political takeover. Trade encouraged these foreign merchants to emigrate to Quanzhou, where many chose to live before the Mongol takeover, enjoying financial success and ascension in the local government's ranks. One of these foreign traders, Pu Shougeng, stands out in his work to secure the Mongol takeover of southern China, the last outpost of Song power. In 1276, Song loyalists launched a resistance against Mongol efforts to take over Fuzhou (near Quanzhou). The *Yuanshi* (the Yuan dynasty official history) records that Pu Shougeng, with the support of the local elite, "abandoned the Song cause and rejected the emperor ... by the end of the year, Quanzhou had formally submitted to the Mongols."¹⁰ In abandoning the Song cause, Pu Shougeng mobilized troops mostly from the community of foreign residents and local elite, who massacred Song clansmen and loyalists. Pu Shougeng and his troops acted without the help of the Mongol army.

Pu Shougeng's support of Mongol conquest comes without surprise, for the Mongols, themselves foreign to China, favoured foreigners for prestigious positions in their bureaucracy. Up until the Yuan Dynasty's fall, Quanzhou's foreigners, or *semuren* (literally, "people with coloured eyes"), had occupied most of the local government's official positions. Moreover, several genealogies and histories show that many locals adopted foreign Chinese names and converted to foreign religions, hoping to enjoy the privileges reserved for members of registered foreign households.¹¹ Pu Shougeng himself was lavishly rewarded by the Mongols. He was appointed military commissioner for the provinces of Fujian and Guangdong. Additionally, in 1278, Pu Shougeng and the Mongol general, Sogetu, were given official positions in the Quanzhou government for promoting maritime trade.¹²

The period of Mongol rule is marked by increased Chinese mercantile activity along the South Indian coastline. Ibn Battuta, Wang Dayuan, and Marco Polo all provide eye witness accounts of Chinese merchants in the Indian ports.¹³ The Kublai Khan court considered trade with India so important that it dispatched an unprecedented sixteen official, diplomatic envoys to India, primarily along the Coromandel and Malabar coasts.¹⁴ The Yuan official Yang Tingbi led several missions to these regions, determined to expand China's political connections with India. Yang's missions are also suggestive of India's pluralistic landscape, for he reports meeting with Syrian

Christian and Muslim communities in South India, undoubtedly comprised of diaspora traders.¹⁵ Moreover, Yuan officials travelled to India on private trading ships, affirming a connection between court and merchant endeavours to expand their reach in Indian markets and politics.¹⁶

From the Indian vantage point, 1281 marks the end of the late Chola period in Tamil Nadu, which began in 1070 with Kulottunga I and ended in 1280 with Rajendra III's demise.¹⁷ Thanks to John Guy, whose stylistic and iconographic analysis convincingly threads the Quanzhou carvings to temples in Tamil Nadu, we know that the Siva-worshipping community in Quanzhou was probably from Tamil Nadu.¹⁸

At the very least, its members had strong ties to this region. As overseas commercial ventures became crucial to ensuring the economic well-being of their polity, the Chola monarchs pursued aggressive foreign policies that established trading networks and political relations with China. The Chinese scholar Ban Gu shows that, as early as the first century, South China and South India were connected by maritime trade routes;¹⁹ however, Quanzhou only emerged as a port of international importance between the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, during the Song dynasty and the Mongol Yuan dynasty. In 1292, it received Marco Polo, who commented on the substantial presence of Indian ships loaded with pepper in the port.²⁰ Archaeological evidence found on the Tamil Nadu coast, including hoards of Chinese ceramics and coins, attest to the vibrant trade between southern India and China, which began in the eleventh century and continued.²¹

In a book on Sino-Indian relations, Tansen Sen argues that the Chola kingdom contributed to the development of the world market, and that "the trading ports and mercantile guilds of the Chola kingdom played a significant role in linking the markets of China to the rest of the world".²² From 1015 onwards, Chola monarchs sent envoys to southern China and actively protected their commercial interests through warfare. In fact, writing on merchant guilds, Meera Abraham has suggested that the Chola naval raid on the Malay Peninsula and Indonesia in 1025 was an effort to protect Indian commercial interests from interference by the Srivijaya kingdom, which occupied an intermediary trade position between China and India.²³ The Cholas also invaded Sri Lanka to expand their control of overseas ports. Furthermore, the Chola monarchs did not act independently in their relations with China; rather, South Indian merchant played a significant role in facilitating cultural exchanges between China and India. In fact, the patrons of the Hindu temple in Quanzhou were most likely members of a merchant guild that had established a permanent trading post there. Meera Abraham charts the intimate relations between king and merchant, putting

into question the commonly held view of the king as a totalitarian ruler bent on absolute overseas authority through military conquest. On the contrary, merchant guilds wielded an immense amount of power in South India's Hindu temples, as well as overseas.

Chinese envoy records illuminate the close relationship between the Chola monarch and merchant guilds. Indeed, Chinese officials could not distinguish between Chola monarch and merchant-sponsored envoys since the identities and affiliations of those present were lost in clerical error and often deliberate misinformation. Competition for larger shares of the market drove individual missionaries to misrepresent themselves. For instance, a Srivijayan envoy succeeded in convincing Chinese officials that the Chola kingdom was a vassal state of Srivijaya in the height of the former's power, resulting in the official mistreatment of the first Chola envoy in 1015.²⁴

Merchant groups were intensely competitive, so much so that they appealed to culture to ensure their position in foreign markets and encourage foreign diplomacy: they built their own religious monuments and patronized others. For instance, the fourteenth century Chinese travel writer, Wang Dayuan, claims to have seen a pagoda in Nagappattinam in Tamil Nadu, built by Chinese sojourners and inscribed in Chinese characters, which reveal a construction date of 1267.²⁵ Additionally, in the eleventh century, Srivijayans built a Buddhist monastery in Nagapattinam using a Chinese architectural style.²⁶ An inscription found in Guangzhou (ca. 1049) records donations made to a Taoist monastery on behalf of the Chola monarch Kulottunga I.²⁷

More interestingly, these monuments were not culturally distinct entities, for the presence of personnel and iconography from multiple cultures is evident in their built-form. For example, the Kaiyuan Temple's gazetteer records that a "Master from India" served as the chief architect in renovating its East pagoda in 1238. Additionally, a bas relief of Hanuman, the monkey prince of the *Ramayana*, appears on one of the temple's pagodas.²⁸ Although it is beyond this paper's scope to analyse material from Central or Southeast Asia, it is worth mentioning that representatives from these regions were present in Quanzhou and may have contributed directly and indirectly to the Siva temple's appearance. Multilingual inscriptions and Indic carvings have been found across Southeast Asia, indicating a wider pattern of migration and settlement by merchants across culturally permeable borders. We suspect the influx of bodies and ideas from Southeast Asia also affected the appearance of the temple and the community of worshippers within Quanzhou.²⁹

Indeed, it appears that the categories of "foreigner" and "merchant" were more salient than "ethno-cultural" identities. While the large volume of literature theorizing merchant networks outpaces this paper, we might simply

note that this scholarship indexes how merchant trade entailed collaboration between multiple, interdependent, and close knit groups, and it cautions against the anachronistic temptation to separate these networks into ethnic or nationally defined entities.

STYLISTIC ANALYSIS OF THE INDIC CARVINGS IN QUANZHOU

Using the word “temple” itself overstates the form of the architectural remains today. The carvings are dispersed across five primary sites in Quanzhou and its surroundings.

The Kaiyuan Temple, which is still an active Buddhist temple built in the Tang period in 686 CE, houses the largest repository of Indic carvings.³⁰ There, 153 of these carvings, mostly installed in the temple’s front hall, have been used as part of the basement frieze (Figure 15.1). Their style and placement suggest they were not part of the temple’s original conception, but are instead reused materials from an Indian temple. The Kaiyuan Temple has survived numerous natural disasters and renovations, recorded in the Ming dynasty gazetteer, the *Record of the Kaiyuan Temple*.³¹ Two separate patrons renovated the temple in 1389 and 1408; the Indic carvings may have been installed in the temple during this time.³²

The basement frieze in the Kaiyuan Temple mirrors its anticipated placement in the Indian temple. Lotus-shaped mouldings frame a sculptural bas-relief panel frieze of lions alternating with half-female, half-lion figures. A complete panel is consistent in length, rectangular, evenly bordered, and has the figural sequence of a lion separated by a column, followed by a leonine figure. Upon close inspection, the varying lengths and breaks in the panel suggest that the stones are not in their original position. More interestingly, the artisans who installed the stones in the basement clearly followed the “original” alternating pattern: lion ... column ... leonine figure. Moreover, they used panel fragments when needed in order to avoid upsetting the sequential order. Two *citrakhandas* columns with sculptural reliefs of Hindu gods appear in the back of the first hall (Figure 15.2). Scholars of the Tamil speaking community in Quanzhou have paid the most attention to these columns,³³ which frame the back entrance to the main hall and sit on a raised stone platform that served as an open air walkway circumambulating the main building.

The second largest repository of Indic carvings exists in the Quanzhou Maritime Museum, located in the city centre. In the 1950’s, Quanzhou

FIGURE 15.1
Kaiyuan Temple, Quanzhou

View of reused Indic carvings in basement frieze, possibly installed in 1389 or 1408.



FIGURE 15.2
Kaiyuan Temple, Quanzhou

View of reused *citrakhandā* type columns in back of main hall.



citizen and collector, Wu Wenliang, first took an interest in unappreciated antiquities lying idle in fields or reused as building materials in local residential homes. He mostly acquired stone carvings, some dating back as early as the eleventh century, which the city's inhabitants had used to build local structures. The Indic carvings comprise about a fourth of his collection, which also includes carvings bearing Christian, Islamic, Manichean, and Nestorian iconography, inscribed with languages such as Persian, Arabic, Tamil, Italian, Latin, and Syriac. Indeed, many of the carvings bear multilingual inscriptions, attesting to a high level of fluidity between ethno-cultural borders, as well as the presence of non-Chinese individuals with local power. For example, "the gravestone of Ahmad" narrates a family who lived in Quanzhou for several generations. Written in Persian, Arabic, and Chinese, we know that the elder Ahmad "married a woman from Quanzhou and that the younger generation became proficient in Chinese".³⁴ A number of the collection's Indic carvings were moved from the Kaiyuan Temple, whose grounds also contain a museum. The Quanzhou Maritime Museum also continues to acquire new carvings through random finds and contributions.³⁵

The 117 pieces of the museum's carvings, are clearly architectural fragments from a South Indian style temple. They include fluted pilasters, *puspapotika* (capitals with flower blossom extensions), *citrakhanda* pillars (square column-type with carved central band), *padma* (lotus petal carved base mouldings), *vyala* bas reliefs (composite leonine figure), *kapota* (cornices), door jambs, *lasuna* (vase shaped pillar part), *ghata* (cushion shaped pillar part above *lasuna*), *malasthana* (decorated pillar part below *ghata*), finials, sculptural panels, *hastihasta* (stairway banister), *jali* (grill pattern window screens), and a five-foot tall Vishnu statue, carved in the round, complete with a lotus petal base. The carvings are in a small exhibition room in the museum's rear; apart from a few display podiums, they are disordered and stacked one upon another (Figure 15.3).

Also in Quanzhou, the Tianhou gong temple holds two *citrakhanda* columns with dimensions roughly approximating the columns in the Kaiyuan Temple and Quanzhou Maritime Museum (Figure 15.4), which suggest they are originally from the same temple. The temple dates to the second year of Qingyuan and the Southern Song dynasty (c. 1196), and is dedicated to the local goddess Mazu, traditionally worshipped by sailors seeking protection against harsh waters. The most noticeable difference between the temples is seen in the medallions of the Tianhou gong temple, which are carved with floral and vegetal motifs and exclude figurative imagery of and references to Hindu iconography. As in the Kaiyuan Temple, the Tianhou gong temple's pillars sit atop a raised stone platform and form part of an ambulatory hall

FIGURE 15.3
Quanzhou Maritime Museum, Quanzhou
Display of Indic carvings.



FIGURE 15.4
Tianhou gong Temple, Quanzhou
Citrakhandā type pillars in back hall.



that surrounds the main building. The pillars stand out insofar as they frame the front door of the rear building.

About 15 kilometres outside of Quanzhou's city centre, in the rural Chidian village of Jinjiang county, a small shrine known as the Xingji pavilion is dedicated to the Buddhist goddess Guanyin; however, there is a large sculptural panel of the Hindu goddess Kali, painted in red and gold in place of the Guanyin icon (Figure 15.5). The goddess bears the iconographic features of Kali, since she has a skull necklace, wild hair, female attendants, and a demon underfoot. As early as seventy years ago, the panel was installed as a shrine next to a small bridge, located about one kilometre away from the village.³⁶ During the Cultural Revolution, the bridge and pavilion were dismantled, and the carvings were cemented into a wall surrounding the village. In the 1980s, the village residents dismantled the wall, found the Kali carving, reconsecrated it as the goddess Guanyin, and built a shrine for it.

The Xiamen University Museum has a small holding of carvings, including the original bilingual inscription (Figure 15.6) and a door jamb.

FIGURE 15.5
Xingji pavilion, Chidian village, Jinjiang county
Indic sculptural panel of Hindu goddess Kali with attendants.



FIGURE 15.6
Xiamen University Museum

Bilingual stele in Tamil and Chinese, recording consecration of Siva temple in 1281.



That the temple was disassembled generates at least a partial history of the carvings. At some point, these carvings ceased to be Hindu in a religious sense. After the temple was disassembled, they no longer served a religious purpose; rather, their symbolism changed and the stones were infused with a new set of meanings. It was only over the past century, when these carvings were gathered in a museum setting, that they once again received a Hindu identity. However, looking at the stones closely, it is clear that even in their original position in a consecrated Hindu temple, they were never unambiguously “Hindu”. Rather, they are the products of several communities and cultural practices whose boundaries are far from clear. Despite the lack of traditionally historical “texts” establishing a Tamil community living in Quanzhou, the stones themselves serve as a text, providing information about their patrons’ politics with respect to medieval Quanzhou society.

Among the surviving Hindu carvings is an inscription, written in both Tamil and Chinese, establishing the consecration of a Siva temple in Quanzhou in 1281. The main portion of the text is written in Tamil, and the last line is written in Chinese. The Tamil text reads:

Obeisance to Hara (Siva). Let there be prosperity! On the day Chitra in the month of Chittirai in the Saka year 1203, the Tavachchakkarvartikal Sambandapperumāl graciously caused, in accordance with the *firman* (written permission) of Chekachai Khan (the Mongol ruler), the installation of the God Uḍaiyar Tiruk-kāniśvaram Uḍaiya-nāyanār (Siva), for the welfare of the king Chekachai Khan.³⁷

This Tamil text offers us several valuable pieces of information: it praises Siva, the primary deity of the temple, names the primary patron,

Sambandhaperumal, a common Tamil name, and asserts that the installation of Siva's image enjoyed the grace of the imperial Mongol authority (Chekachai Khan). Clearly, Indian patrons responsible for building the temple acted under the auspices of the Chinese imperial authorities. Though the Chinese text has proved elusive for scholars, the disagreements over its appropriate translation reveal in form more than they obscure in substance.³⁸ Although the substance of the text is opaque, its form begs a number of questions. The Tamil letters are poorly formed, suggesting that the scribe was not formally trained in the Tamil script. The ethnicity of the scribe, however, is indeterminable and actually irrelevant for our purposes. Rather, that these two languages appear side by side attests to the salience of both languages within the community.

The bilingual inscription indicates that the temple's patrons spoke to at least three linguistic audiences: Chinese speaking, Tamil speaking, and a third bilingual space. Whether the temple's patrons used Chinese or Tamil to communicate with other members of the Quanzhou society cannot be known for sure. Furthermore, Tamil may not have been the worshippers' mother tongue. For temple inscriptions, Tamil language inscriptions may index symbolic reverence rather than actual vernacular use. However, at the very least, the Tamil portion of the inscription — and not the Chinese — recognizes and salutes the Mongol Khanate. For Phil Wagoner, who writes on a mosque built in the medieval Deccan, "[the] architectural action is part of a symbolic political transaction, in which the merit accruing from the building's foundation is dedicated to... [the] overlord".³⁹ In my case, the dharma-accruing overlord is the Mongol Khanate, Chekachai Khan, suggesting that the temple's inscribed tribute was intended for him. This is not to say that Quanzhou's non-Indian inhabitants were proficient in Tamil. Rather, the Tamil homage suggests that a knowledgeable, perhaps bilingual community was present to recognize the significance of the inscription and to convey that significance to the Mongol authority. In other words, by the time the temple was built, Quanzhou's South Indian merchant community had engrained itself in the city's social fabric, so much so that it was not only capable of recognizing the Chinese authority's political sovereignty: but it was also *recognizable* in the Chinese community.

Building a temple is a serious commitment, in terms of patronage, planning, and construction, suggesting that Quanzhou's South Indian merchant community considered itself a permanent part of the city's fabric. And yet, many of Quanzhou's Indic carvings are strikingly South Indian in style, so much so that art historian Coomaraswamy remarked that "the Chinese work so closely reproduces Indian ... formulae and style as to give

the impression of Indian workmanship, at first sight”.⁴⁰ For example, the Quanzhou columns (Figure 15.7) almost mimic in form those found at the Airavatesvara temple in Darasuram in Tamil Nadu (Figure 15.8), a twelfth century imperial temple built by Rajaraja II.⁴¹

However, a closer look at some of Quanzhou’s columns reveal conceptual and craft contributions from multiple communities. While the “cultural” identities of the temple’s builders are difficult to determine definitively, evidence exists to suggest that they included artisans knowledgeable of both South Indian and Chinese building techniques. Consider the two Indian columns in Quanzhou’s Buddhist temple, of the *citrakhandā* type, used extensively in the *mandapas* of late Chola temples,⁴² and unprecedented in

FIGURE 15.7
Kaiyuan Temple
Citrakhandā column.



FIGURE 15.8
Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram, Tamil Nadu
 ca. 12th century *Citrakhandā* type columns in *mandapa*,



Chinese architecture. The columns are chamfered to a sixteen-sided form, possess three cubical blocks bearing medallions, and contain forms derived from both Chinese and Indian precedents. Images in the centre of each medallion alternate between Chinese and Indian motifs. For example, one medallion depicts an image of Krishna, an avatar of Vishnu, felling the Arjuna tree (Figure 15.9), and another contains a Chinese chasing phoenix motif (Figure 15.10). This is not to say that similarities between the Darasuram and the Quanzhou temples' columns do not exist. Indeed, looking at the columns' capitals, extremely precise parallels clearly exist. The capitals, no longer attached to the columns, are currently housed in the Quanzhou Maritime Museum (Figure 15.11). They consist of petalled "spouts" from which pendant lotuses hang. Put next to the capitals of a non-Imperial, late Chola temple of Tiruvilimilalai, the Quanzhou capitals appear as precise mimicries (Figures 15.12 and 13).⁴³

FIGURE 15.9
Kaiyuan Temple

Medallion on column; Krishna felling Arjuna tree.



FIGURE 15.10
Kaiyuan Temple

Medallion on column; Chasing phoenix motif.



FIGURE 15.11
Quanzhou Maritime Museum
Capitals of Indic Columns



FIGURE 15.12
Tiruvilamilalai Temple, Tamil Nadu Capital, ca. 13th century



FIGURE 15.13
Tiruvilamilalai Capital and column in *mandapa*



The artistic climate in the thirteenth century Quanzhou was clearly multicultural. The temple patrons comprised but one of the many foreign communities living there at the time. As already mentioned, in the thirteenth century, Quanzhou served as one of the world's largest port cities. It housed Arabs, Persians, Europeans, and other minority groups, in addition to a substantial Indian population. All of these groups commissioned buildings and monuments that can be seen in Quanzhou today. Looking at these monuments' ornaments, in particular, alongside that of the Quanzhou columns, we see similarities. For example, bands containing a scrolling peony and lotus motif (Figure 15.14) encircle the chamfered parts of the Quanzhou columns. This ornamental motif appears on a Christian gravestone from the same period (Figure 15.15).⁴⁴ The cloud motif is also ubiquitous on a variety of Quanzhou's cultural monuments. It appears clearly on the writing support on the side of a colossal statue of a Daoist deity, located in the hills outside of the city (Figures 15.16 and 17), in an Indic carving (Figure 15.18), as well as on the bottom portion of a gravestone with Arabic script, dated to 1302

FIGURE 15.14
Kaiyuan Temple

Band on column with scrolling peony and lotus motif.



FIGURE 15.15
Quanzhou Maritime Museum

Christian gravestone with scrolling peony and lotus motif.



FIGURE 15.16
Qingyuan shan slope, Quanzhou Colossal Daoist deity



FIGURE 15.17
Detail of Daoist deity armrest showing cloud motif



FIGURE 15.18
Quanzhou Maritime Museum
Indic carving with cloud motif



(Figure 15.19). Considering that identical forms of ornament were used to adorn a variety of city monuments, regardless of cultural origin, it seems likely that patrons of diverse communities employed the same group of artisans.

Furthermore, these artisans were probably local Chinese, evident, for instance, through comparing the execution of Chinese and Indian ornamental medallions. Consider the Chinese chasing phoenix pattern that appears both on a medallion of the Indic, Kaiyuan Temple column, and on a Southern Song dynasty (1127–1279) silver box, taken from a tomb in nearby Fuzhou (Figure 15.20). The chasing phoenix appears regularly in Chinese — not Indian — imagery from this period.⁴⁵ On both, the phoenix is balanced and symmetrical; its wings are positioned seamlessly against a border; and, its feathers are sharply defined. By contrast, the image of Krishna felling the Arjuna tree (new to Chinese artisans), located on a medallion of the temple's Indic column, lacks the same degree of symmetrical organization: the image of Krishna exists within blank, unornamented space.

Moreover, comparing Indian images found on the Kaiyuan Temple columns with the same images regnant on late Chola temples in India further

FIGURE 15.19
Quanzhou Maritime Museum

Detail of gravestone with Arabic script and cloud motif, c. 1302.



FIGURE 15.20
Fuzhou Museum

Fuzhou Box with chasing phoenix motif, ca. 1127–1279



accentuates the former's lack of precision. A Quanzhou medallion depicting wrestlers (Figure 15.21) bears a striking resemblance to a bas relief of wrestlers from the late Chola temple of Darasuram (Figure 15.22). In both, the wrestlers' bodies form a circle and the limbs cross one another at the central point; however, in the Darasuram carving, the bodies are carved precisely, in a continuous, fluid circle, while the Quanzhou wrestlers appear crammed inside the border, struggling awkwardly against the medallion's confines.

It seems the craftsmen responsible for carving the medallions were not accustomed to carving Indian subject matter and relied on a medium other than sculpture for design. But, as we saw, the columns' capitals nearly mimic those in Tamil Nadu. Perhaps the columns were built by Chinese and Tamil artisans in collaboration: the latter responsible for their overall form and the former for the ornament. But this answer only begs more questions. For instance, did the temple's patrons recognize Chinese and Indian motifs as

FIGURE 15.21

Kaiyuan Temple

Detail of medallion on column with wrestlers.



FIGURE 15.22
Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram, ca. 12th century
 Detail of bas-relief panel with wrestlers.



“culturally” distinct? What criteria determined image selection? If nothing else, by grafting local Chinese iconography onto their religious centre, South Indian patrons, consciously or not, effectively forged their identities in relation to southern China’s cultural landscape.

More pointedly, the built-form of Quanzhou’s columns appears immune to cultural hierarchy: Indian and Chinese subject matter are nearly interchangeable.

CONCLUSION

Quanzhou’s Siva temple is a comment on visual translation in the late thirteenth-century world. At points, the temple appears strikingly South Indian in style. At others, the form reveals alteration and innovation, situated in a “multicultural” context. Questions linger: why does the temple

appear mimetically South Indian where it does, especially since a Chinese artisan majority appears to have led the construction effort? On the one hand, one would expect that Mongol policies privileging foreigners encouraged foreign patron communities to adopt an aesthetics of difference, to denote an elevated status. Though if this were the case, why does Quanzhou's Siva temple refuse to mimic a typical Tamil temple style? Here, I offer one of many possible hypotheses: the temple patrons' reliance on a shared community of local Quanzhou artisans. When denied precise direction, these artisans must have relied on their own understanding of ornamentation.⁴⁶ A more robust answer to this question requires knowledge of the temple's appearance in full, in order to uncover the political, social, cultural, and economic "logics" of aesthetic variation in the temple's built-form.

So as not to overdetermine the explanatory power of aesthetic variation in the temple's built-form, I want to conclude by reiterating that my analysis is one, complementary dimension of a larger picture. I read Quanzhou's Siva temple as a historical moment, instantiating an otherwise typical movement of people and ideas in the thirteenth-century world. This moment factors into a much longer history (preceding and subsequent) of the exchange of commodities, personnel, knowledge, and gods, between India and its outside world.⁴⁷ While the late thirteenth century, when the Quanzhou Siva temple was built, marks a period of heightened relations between China and India, it was by no means a singular moment. After all, people and practices had been circulating between India and China since at least the third century. Quanzhou's Siva temple, as a historical moment, narrates the inextricable link between circulation on the one hand, and transformation, on the other.

Notes

1. I am indebted to Barry Flood, Katherine Kasdorf, and Vidya Dehejia for reading versions of this chapter, offering bibliographic suggestions, and productive conversation. Any remaining shortcomings are my own.

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2. The use of granite is unique to the region. The most concise English language Quanzhou archaeological survey is Richard Pearson, Li Min, and Li Guo,

- “Quanzhou Archaeology: A Brief Review”, *International Journal of Historical Archaeology* 6, no. 1 (March 2002).
3. My work owes much to Phil Wagoner and Barry Flood’s scholarship which, in studying the art object, takes seriously movement and the remapping of cultural boundaries. Barry Flood, “Pillars, Palimpsests, and Princely Practices: Translating the Past in Sultanate Delhi”, *Res* 43 (Spring 2003). Phil Wagoner, “Fortuitous Convergences and Essential Ambiguities: Transcultural Political Elites in the Medieval Deccan”, *International Journal of Hindu Studies* 3, no. 3 (December 1999).
 4. T.N. Subramaniam, “A Tamil Colony in Medieval India”. In *South Indian Studies*, edited by R. Nagaswamy (Madras, 1978), pp. 1–52.
 5. Hugh Clark, “Muslims and Hindus in the Culture and Morphology” (1995); Dasheng Cheng, *Quanzhou yisilanjiao shike* [Islamic Stone Reliefs in Quanzhou] (Fuzhou: Fujian People’s Press, 1984); Ellen Wang, “Quanzhou Kaiyuan Monastery: Architecture, Iconography, and Social Contexts”, unpublished Ph.D. dissertation in East Asian Languages and Civilizations, University of Pennsylvania, 2008.
 6. Hugh Clark, “Muslims and Hindus in the Culture and Morphology of Quanzhou from the Tenth to Thirteenth Century”, *Journal of World History* 6, no. 1 (Spring 1995): 49–74.
 7. Most Quanzhou scholars believe that the temple was dismantled in the late sixteenth century, owing to a local gazetteer that records a renovation of the Buddhist temple at this time. Scholars have assumed that the Indic carvings installed into the foundation of the Buddhist temple were a part of this renovation; however, there is no other material evidence as yet to prove this conclusively.
 8. Qingzhang Yang, “Quanzhou Yindujiao Diaoke Yuanyuan Kao”, *Quanzhougang Yu Haishang Sichouzhilu*, edited by Zhongguo Haiyang Xuehui, Quanzhou Shizhengfu (Beijing: Sheke Chubanshe, 2002), pp. 427–39.
 9. John Guy, “Tamil Merchant Guilds and the Quanzhou Trade”. In *Emporium of the World: Maritime Quanzhou, 1000–1400*, edited by Angela Schottenhammer (Leiden and Boston: Brill, 2000), pp. xi, 449; Qingzhang Yang, “Cultural Contacts Between China’s Quanzhou and South India During the Yuan Period: New Evidence”, *Asia-Pacific Studies* (1991): 99–111.
 10. The Mongols also gained control of Fuzhou and Guangzhou, two vital ports. The merchant, Pu Shougeng, is believed to have been of either Arabic or Persian background. His great grandfather traded in the South Seas and gained great success. The successive generations then moved first to Guangzhou, then to Quanzhou. Billy K. L. So, *Prosperity, Region, and Institutions in Maritime China* (Cambridge, MA and London: Harvard University Press, 2000), p. 108.
 11. *Ibid.*
 12. Tansen Sen, “The Formation of Chinese Maritime Networks to Southern Asia, 1200–1450”, *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 49, no. 4 (2006): 432.

13. Tansen Sen, "The Yuan Khanate and India: Cross-Cultural Diplomacy in the Thirteenth and Fourteenth Centuries". *Asia Major* 19, no. 1-2 (2006): 299–326.
14. Ibid.
15. The *Yuanshi* records Tingbi's visits to India. Also attesting to the close relationships between the countries is Yang Tingbi offering asylum to a local Muslim official, Sayyid, who was at odds with the south Indian court (Ma'abar). Sayyid was brought to China and granted a Korean bride by Kublai Khan. Ibid, 317.
16. Ibn Battuta writes of "Chinese merchants offering clothes to Yuan envoys whose belongings were lost in a shipwreck". Ibid., p. 323.
17. It is probably no coincidence that the temple in China is founded so soon after the dissolution of the Chola empire. Sen also notes that the temple is erected only a few years after Yang Tingbi's first mission to India. In Tansen Sen's article, "The Yuan Khanate and India".
18. John Guy, "The Lost Temples of Nagapattinam and Quanzhou: A Study in Sino-Indian Relations", *Silk Road Art and Archaeology* 3 (1993/1994).
19. Ban Gu, "who lived not later than the end of the first century A.D." writes of trade with India in his work, *Qian Hanshu*. Quoted in K. A. Nilakanta Sastri, *Foreign Notices of South India* (Madras: University of Madras, 1972), p. 44.
20. John Guy, "The Lost Temples of Nagapattinam and Quanzhou".
21. It might be productive to investigate the continued trade between India and China, even though it postdates the foundation inscription of the Hindu temple. We know for a fact that Chinese silk was an important part of court ritual in India as late as the Vijayanagar period. See Phil Wagoner, "Lord of the Eastern and Western Oceans: Politics and the Indian Ocean Trade in South India, 1400–1600", paper presented at the Association for Asian Studies Annual Meeting, 26–29 March 1998, Washington, D.C.
22. Tansen Sen, *Buddhism, Diplomacy and Trade: The Realignment of Sino-Indian Relations 600–1400* (Honolulu: Association for Asian Studies: University of Hawai'i Press, 2003), p. 156.
23. A kingdom that is believed to have been located in the Southern Malay peninsula and Sumatra. Meera Abraham, *Two Medieval Merchant Guilds of South India* (New Delhi: Manohar Publications, 1988).
24. Tansen Sen, *Buddhism, Diplomacy, and Trade*, p. 224.
25. This structure was demolished in 1867. There are other Chinese records that describe Chinese temples being built in South India at the bequest of the Pallava king, Narasimhavarman II (690–720). Guy, "Lost Temples of Nagapattinam and Quanzhou".
26. Recorded in the larger Leiden Grant. Meera Abraham, *Two Medieval Merchant Guilds*.
27. There are even earlier records than this: a Chinese source states that in 720 the Pallava king Narasimhavarman II "constructed a temple [in Tamil Nadu] on account of the empire [i.e. China]", and another text cites the existence of three

- Hindu temples in southern China where “Brahmans” resided during the eighth century. Chinese patrons also established Buddhist temples in Tamil Nadu during the Pallava and Chola periods. See John Guy, “The Lost Temples of Nagapattinam and Quanzhou”, p. 293 and “Tamil Merchant Guilds and the Quanzhou Trade”, in *Foreign Notices of South India*, by K. A. Nilakanta Sastri, p. 118.
28. Many scholars believe that Hanuman became incorporated into Chinese Buddhism and became Sun Wukong, the monkey assistant to Hsuan Tsang. For a summary of the debates, see Victor Mair, “Suen Wu-kung or Hanumat? The Progress of a Scholarly Debate”, in *Proceedings of the Second International Conference on Sinology* (Taipei: Academia Sinica, 1989), pp. 659–752.
 29. Tansen Sen notes a number of stones along the South Indian coast that have been inscribed in Arabic and South Indian languages, such as the Galle inscription of Tamil, Chinese, Persian, and Sinhalese. This is not to mention the numerous multilingual inscriptions found throughout Southeast Asia. Moreover, Sen suggests that at least by the Ming dynasty, Chinese merchants had established mercantile bases in Southeast Asia, making the Indian coastline much more accessible. There is equal evidence for the south Indian merchants having set up similar settlements. See Sen, “Formations of Maritime Networks”; H.P. Ray, “Indian Settlements in Medieval China: A Preliminary Study”, *Indian Journal of Asian Studies* 1, no. 1 (1989): 68–82, and Jan Wisseman Christie, “The Medieval Tamil-language Inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China”, *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies* 29, no. 2 (1998): 239–68.
 30. Shi Yuanxian, *Quanzhou Kaiyuansi Zhi* [Record of Kaiyuan Temple] (1643 Nian, Mukenben), 1–4 Juan, Xiamen Daxue Tushuguan Cang. Gustav Ecke and Paul Demiéville argue that its current plan is no earlier than the Song dynasty. In *The Twin Pagodas of Zayton: a Study of Later Buddhist Sculpture in China* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1935).
 31. The gazetteer dates to 1643, but it incorporates versions authored as early as the Tang dynasty. It was written by Shi Yuanxian, a monk from Fuzhou, Fujian province.
 32. These dates are tentative since no written record specifies the Indic carvings’ installation date. Ellen Wang, “Quanzhou Kaiyuan Monastery: Architecture, Iconography, and Social Contexts” (unpublished Ph.D. dissertation, University of Pennsylvania, 2008).
 33. See T.N. Subramaniam, “A Tamil Colony in Medieval India”, in *South Indian Studies*, edited by R. Nagaswamy (Madras, 1978); A.K. Coomaraswamy, “Hindu Sculptures at Zayton”, *Ostasiatische. Zeitschrift*, Vol. 9 (1933), p. 5; and John Guy, “The Lost Temples.”
 34. Pearson et al., p. 41. There are also twenty-eight gravestones that record five generations of a family from Sri Lanka with the surname “Shi,” gravestones from the Ming and Qing dynasties. There are mentions of the Sri Lankan family in genealogies, and a land contract from Guangzhou. Recorded in Wenliang and

- Youxiong Wu's, *Quanzhou Zong Jiao Shi Ke*, Zeng ding ben, Di 1 ban. Ed. (Beijing: Kexue chubanshe, 2005).
35. During my stay in Quanzhou, the museum received two new carvings, both of which appeared to be portions of temple base moulding. These were gifted by a resident who had found them underneath their house. Since Quanzhou has been continuously occupied from the Tang dynasty onwards, there are unquestionably more carvings that have been reused as building materials for private homes.
 36. This is from my talk with a resident of the village, who had lived there from childhood and remembered seeing the panel *in situ* by the bridge. I estimated him to be about 75 years old. Although we cannot determine the construction date of this bridge because it has been dismantled, we can assume that it was an older bridge because it was targeted by Mao Zedong's anti-culture campaigns. Monks traditionally built bridges to accrue *dharma*, or religious merit and small pavilions near to the bridges containing sculptures are a common architectural feature. To my knowledge, there has been no involved scholarship of either bridges or pavilions of Fujian province; however, the region is renowned for its profusion of extant bridges, many of which date as early as the Song dynasty. See Hugh Clark, *Community, Trade, and Networks: Southern Fujian Province from the Third to the Thirteenth Century* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1991).
 37. Barry Flood has noted that the term *firman*, is a Persianized Arabic term, which furthers my argument that Indic temple patrons did not view themselves as culturally distinct selves; rather, such terms were transcultural.
 38. Tansen Sen uses the following translation: "Lu-ho-chih-jih, [who was] good in Chinese [language], compiled the sutra of the Great mountain without the help of a Guru." David Yu, an independent scholar, has recently suggested that it is a phonetic version of the title, "Tavachhavartigal," intelligible when the characters are read in Fujianese dialect. Most Chinese speaking scholars, however, are unable to read anything. Tansen Sen, "Maritime Contacts between China and the Cola Kingdom (AD 850–1279)", in *Mariners, Merchants, and Oceans: Studies in Maritime History*, edited by Kuzhippalli Skaria Mathew (New Delhi: Manohar, 1995), p. 33.
 39. Wagoner also writes about this mosque or *dharmaśāle* as evidence of "the fluid nature of individual identity and the permeability of cultural boundaries in the Deccan". Phil Wagoner, "Fortuitous Convergences and Essential Ambiguities: Transcultural Political Elites in the Medieval Deccan", *International Journal of Hindu Studies* 3, no. 3 (December 1999): 253.
 40. A.K. Coomaraswamy, "Hindu Sculptures at Zayton", p. 5.
 41. See Françoise L'Hernault, P.R., Srinivasan, and Jacques Dumarçay, *Darasuram: epigraphical study, etude architecturale, etude iconographique*, Publications de l'école Française d'extreme-Orient. Memoires Archéologiques 16. Paris: Ecole française d'extreme-orient: Depositaire Libr. A.: Maisonneuve, 1987.

42. Michael W. Meister et al., *Encyclopaedia of Indian Temple Architecture* (New Delhi, Philadelphia: American Institute of Indian Studies; University of Pennsylvania Press, 1983), p. 294.
43. S.R. Balasubrahmanyam, S.R. Natarajan B., B. Venkataraman, and Ramachandran B., *Later Chola Temples: Kulottunga I to Rajendra III (AD 1070–1280)* (Madras: Mudgala Trust, 1979).
44. Iain Gradner, Samuel Lieu, and Ken Parry, *From Palmyra to Zayton: Epigraphy and Iconography* (Belgium: Brepols Publishers, 2005).
45. It has been suggested that this motif came into fruition during the Yuan dynasty. Jessica Rawson, *Chinese Ornament: The Lotus and the Dragon* (London: British Museum Publications, 1984) and James C. Watt, *When Silk Was Gold: Central Asian and Chinese Textiles* (New York: H.N. Abrams, 1997).
46. Rawson, *The Lotus and the Dragon*.
47. Claude Markovits, Jacques Pouchpadass, and Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *Society and Circulation: Mobile People and Itinerant Cultures in South Asia, 1750–1950* (Delhi; Bangalore: Permanent Black, 2003).

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